

CNL-518 Topic 8: Bereavement Across the Life Span

Directions: One's understanding of death and the bereavement process changes over the life span. Using the matrix provided below, summarize how individuals perceive the loss of a loved one throughout the lifespan. Create a short vignette for each age group and include the role of spirituality and/or Christian principles in the process. Include developmentally appropriate, ethical, and culturally relevant counseling interventions for promoting resilience and optimum development and wellness. Each stage should include at least one scholarly citation. Write in complete sentences. The first stage has been completed for you as an example. Include at least two peer-reviewed, scholarly sources and an APA formatted reference page.

Age Group	Perception of Grief	Vignette Provide an example of loss, and include the role of spirituality and/or Christian principles in the process.	Counseling Interventions Include developmentally appropriate, ethical, and culturally relevant counseling interventions for promoting resilience and optimum development and wellness.
Baby and Toddler	Perception of grief: Based on Piaget's theory that characterizes children's concepts as egocentric, a baby's perception or cognition of grief would be limited to a sense of fear and loss due to separation anxiety (Slaughter, 2005).	Vignette: The baby's mother unexpectedly dies after a short illness. The baby had bonded and was feeling safe with their primary caregiver; however, the loss creates stress and confusion for the child. The brother and sister of the mother become the baby's guardians, but the baby is not bonding well with them. The new guardians seek support at their local church by requesting prayer and seeking fellowship.	Counseling interventions: To support the family system, structural family therapy would provide opportunities for conceptualization and restructuring of the new family system through a family therapy map. The family therapy map is different from a genogram because it considers intrafamily dynamics, social and life context stressors (Calapinto, 2019). The family therapy map provides a visual representation to better explore patterns of behavior, interactions, and possible protective factors.

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Preschool Age	Children in this stage do not yet have a clear understanding of death. Since preschoolers are in the preoperational stage, their thinking is characterized by egocentrism and magical beliefs (Gelism University, 2021). Additionally, their limited grasp of continuity makes it difficult for them to comprehend that death is a permanent and irreversible event (Gelism University, 2021).	A 4-year-old boy is experiencing stress and frustration after the death of the family pet. He keeps asking when the pet will wake up and when they can play together again. He struggles to understand that the pet is gone and is not coming back. His parents may tell him that the pet is in heaven with God, and that he will see him again someday.	The 4-year-old may benefit from play therapy, the use of stuffed animals and other toys to express his feelings about what happened to his pet. It's also important to use simple language to convey the truth of what happened without either confusing the boy or leading him to believe in something entirely different from reality.
Grade School Age	During this stage, the child is in the concrete operational phase, transitioning from preoperational thinking toward more abstract reasoning (Kail & Cavanaugh, 2022). At this point, they have developed an understanding of time, distinguishing between past, present, and future. This growing awareness of time allows them to grasp that death is a permanent and ongoing process (Gelism University, 2021).	An 8-year-old girl is experiencing intense sadness and grief after the passing of her grandmother, whom she was very close to. She tries to hide the way she feels by isolating herself. At school, she spends a lot of time in the bathroom, so the other kids don't see her crying. Her parents remind her that Jesus too experienced grief, and he himself cried as it reads in the bible.	It's important to let her know that what she is feeling is normal, and it's okay to miss her grandmother. Encourage her to engage in faith based coping strategies such as praying for strength or comfort during this difficult time.

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Adolescence /Teenage Years	During adolescence, the understanding of death evolves as cognitive development and learning advance. With the emergence of abstract thinking, adolescents begin to think symbolically, reflect on their own thoughts, and develop theories (Kail & Cavanaugh, 2022). These cognitive changes shape their perception of death, allowing them to conceptualize it in more abstract terms. They often question the meaning and purpose of life, seeking philosophical and religious explanations for death, even though they recognize its unpredictability (Gelism University, 2021).	A 17-year-old boy was in a car accident where he lost his best friend. He is struggling with not only the loss of his friend, but he is also feeling a bit of survivor's guilt. He knows his friend is gone, and he questions why God would let something so bad happen to someone so good. This causes him to be angry with God. He is encouraged to read scripture and focus on the present and future rather than the past. He also is encouraged to pray and ask God for guidance, and to ask why this has happened.	I would encourage him to join a grief support group to speak with others who are experiencing something similar. Studies and expert agreement indicate that most individuals experiencing grief will manage their pain through a natural grieving process without requiring professional intervention. With time, their emotional distress typically lessens, and they gradually begin to heal (Newsom et al., 2017). However, if his grief lasts longer than the normal process, I will also encourage that he engages in grief counseling if he feels the need for it.
Adulthood	In early adulthood, individuals typically focus on life pursuits such as marriage, career development, and securing employment, making death a less prominent concern during this stage (Gelism University, 2021). In middle adulthood, declining physical abilities and the onset of health issues lead to increased reflection on mortality and a greater acceptance of death (Gelism University, 2021).	A 55-year-old man just lost his wife. With the death of his spouse, he is unsure what his life will entail because their plans for retirement are no longer relevant. Death was never given much thought because of how young they are. He is overcome with grief and is struggling to accept the death of his wife.	With his recent loss taking such a great toll on him, he begins to go to therapy where he practices faith-based cognitive behavioral therapy. He challenges his feelings of sorry and hopelessness and learns to rely on God and his savior for strength. He also becomes more involved in his community to help him focus on moving forward.

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Late Adulthood	Research indicates that in late adulthood, concerns about death tend to diminish as individuals perceive it as a more immediate and natural part of life (Gelism University, 2021). As physical and cognitive abilities decline, individuals start to feel the effects more intensely. They experience the loss of loved ones more frequently and become more aware of their own mortality. As a result, it is believed that they begin to prepare for death and contemplate it more than they did in middle adulthood (Gelism University, 2021).	An 82-year-old lady has just lost her husband to old age. She knows that this is part of the cycle of life and knew that he was closer to death than life. Before he passed, they both made peace with death with the understanding that they would soon see each other again in a life after this one. She knows that God has prepared a place for them in heaven, and she looks forward to seeing him again.	I would encourage her to engage in self-reflection exercises. This will help her remember the good times her and her husband shared together. She may also benefit from joining a weekly prayer circle with members of her local congregation. Gaining support from her community to help take care of her yard and other tasks she can no longer do by herself.

References

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